Tableau Governance & Administration Framework

Institutional BI Platform: Peer Benchmarking Project (OSU & Public Land-Grant Universities)

Prepared by Hashika Venkatramanan

1. Purpose

This document defines the governance standards, administrative practices, and lifecycle management processes used to build, maintain, and retire analytics assets within this institutional BI project. It reflects the same governance discipline applied to Tableau platform administration in a live enterprise environment: consistent design standards, controlled access, ongoing quality assurance, and a defined path from intake to retirement for every dashboard and data source.

The project itself uses IPEDS (Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System) data to benchmark Oklahoma State University against eight peer public land-grant institutions across enrollment, retention, and graduation outcomes from 2018 to 2023. The framework below is written as it would apply within a university Data & Analytics division managing Tableau Server or Tableau Cloud.

2. User Roles and Permissions

Access to published dashboards, workbooks, and underlying data sources is governed by role-based permission tiers. Every user is assigned the minimum level of access required to complete their responsibilities.

Role	Typical User	Permissions
Viewer	Department staff, program leadership	View and interact with published dashboards; export summary views; no access to underlying workbook or data source.
Explorer	Analysts, program coordinators	All Viewer permissions, plus the ability to create personal worksheets from certified data sources and save private views.
Creator	D&A analysts, dashboard developers	All Explorer permissions, plus authoring new workbooks, publishing to shared projects, and editing data source connections.
Site Administrator	Tableau Administrator	Full platform governance: user provisioning, license assignment, project and folder structure, security settings, usage auditing, and performance monitoring.

Permission changes follow a documented request-and-approval process: a role change request is submitted, reviewed against the requestor's actual project needs, and applied at the lowest sufficient tier. Access is reviewed at least twice per year, and any account inactive for more than 180 days is flagged for review and, if unused, deactivated to keep the license pool accurate.

3. Site and Project Structure

Consistent organization is what makes a Tableau site usable at scale. This project follows a folder and naming structure designed to mirror how a university D&A team would organize dashboards across multiple departments:

- Projects are organized by subject area (Enrollment & Retention, Student Outcomes, Financial Aid) rather than by requestor, so related dashboards stay together regardless of who built them.

- Workbook names follow a consistent pattern: [Subject Area] – [Metric] – [Year Range], e.g. “Enrollment – Peer Institution Comparison – 2018-2023.”
- Data sources intended for reuse across multiple dashboards are published and certified separately from individual workbooks, so updates propagate without rebuilding each dashboard.
- Draft or in-progress work is kept in a clearly labeled “Sandbox” project, separate from certified, production-ready dashboards, so viewers never mistake an unfinished workbook for a validated one.

4. Quality Assurance Checklist

Before any dashboard is published or promoted from Sandbox to a production project, it passes through the following checklist:

- Data accuracy: totals and rates are spot-checked against the original IPEDS source export.
- Labeling: axis titles, legends, and sheet titles are complete and free of default field names (e.g., no unrenamed “DRVEF2023_RV” labels).
- Accessibility: color palettes are checked for sufficient contrast, and no information is conveyed by color alone without a corresponding label or legend.
- Consistency: date ranges, filters, and institution lists match across all sheets within the same dashboard.
- Documentation: each workbook includes a short description of its data source, refresh cadence, and intended audience.

A dashboard is only moved to a production project once every item on this list has been verified by someone other than the original developer, consistent with a standard peer-review step.

5. Usage Monitoring and Performance

Once published, dashboards are not left unmonitored. Ongoing administration includes:

- Reviewing view counts and unique visitors periodically to identify dashboards that are heavily used versus rarely accessed.
- Flagging dashboards with no views over a defined period (e.g., 6 months) as candidates for archival.
- Monitoring load times and simplifying overly complex views (excessive marks, unfiltered large datasets) that slow down rendering.
- Tracking data source extract refresh schedules to confirm dashboards reflect current data rather than stale extracts.

6. Lifecycle Management

Every analytics asset in this project follows the same lifecycle, from initial request through eventual retirement:

Stage	Activity
Intake	A dashboard request is logged with its business question, intended audience, and required data sources.
Prioritization	Requests are assessed for effort, impact, and overlap with existing dashboards before development begins.
Development	The dashboard is built in the Sandbox project using certified data sources where available.
Testing & QA	The Section 4 checklist is completed and reviewed by a second person.

Deployment	The dashboard is published to its production project and access permissions are assigned.
Maintenance	Data refreshes are monitored, and the dashboard is updated as source data or business questions change.
Archival / Retirement	Dashboards with no recent usage or superseded by newer versions are archived, and stakeholders are notified before removal.

7. Data Sources and Documentation

This project draws exclusively from IPEDS, the U.S. Department of Education's public postsecondary data collection system. Institutions included are Oklahoma State University and eight peer public land-grant universities: University of Arkansas, Kansas State University, Iowa State University, University of Nebraska-Lincoln, Texas Tech University, Mississippi State University, Auburn University, and University of Missouri. Data spans academic years 2018 through 2023 and includes total, full-time, part-time, and undergraduate enrollment; full-time cohort retention rate; and total-cohort graduation rate.

All data preparation steps, including field selection and any recoding, are documented in the accompanying project repository so the pipeline can be reproduced or extended to additional institutions or years.